> looked on with astonishment at the bowling and batting of the English players. But it does not appear that they were ever tempted to lay aside their flowing robes and huge turbans and enter the field as competitors. On the other hand, our countrymen attended their cocks, quails and other fighting animals, and, betting freely, lost or won their rupees in the best possible humour.[19]

More surprisingly, Gleig claimed that the Afghans also developed a taste for amateur theatricals. ‘The British officers got up some plays,’ he wrote.

> A theatre was constructed, scenery painted, dresses prepared and excellent bands in attendance. The pieces chosen were chiefly comedies, such as the ‘Irish Ambassador’ and others of the same sort, and great amusement was afforded the audience. For on such occasions they changed the titles of the *dramatis personae*, so as to bring them and the offices of the parties bearing them to the level of Afghan comprehension, while Burnes translated the speeches as they were uttered. The Afghans are a merry people, and have a keen relish of the ludicrous and satirical; and as the interpreter never failed to bring the jokes of the actors home to them, they marked their delight by bursting into peals of laughter.[20]

As late summer turned to autumn, and the nights began to grow longer and colder, the troops were issued with sheepskin clothes, warm gloves and quilts. It was now deemed to be the hunting season and those foxhounds which had made it alive through the Bolan Pass without starving or being eaten by the camp followers were now taken out daily to hunt jackals. Snipe- and duck-shooting also became popular diversions, as did, a little later, skating and snowman building. ‘We appeared in skates manufactured by ourselves,’ wrote Thomas Seaton, ‘and figured away on the ice to the utter amazement of the Kabul people who as they had never seen such a spectacle, came running together to witness the performance. We enjoyed the winter as thoroughly as circumstances would permit – shooting, snow-balling, making snow giants, and picnics to the lake, for the weather was frequently most enjoyable. How clear, how blue and how cloudless it was!’

Shuja meanwhile was busy rebuilding the Bala Hisar and trying to return it to the glories he remembered from his youth, remaking it as a palace which befitted his elevated ideas of kingship. The high walls and bastions ringing the high rock were in good repair; what was not to his liking was the refinements of the palace buildings perching on the terraces within. So, starting with the durbar hall, Shuja refurbished and repainted the plasterwork and repaired the balustrades and the arcades. The Mughal gardens were replanted and a new harem sarai designed from scratch to be ready for his womenfolk when they arrived from Ludhiana. At the same time the court ceremonial was altered to bring back the more formal court